

Mass Medicine

The mother of all health camps ensures that 50,000 tribals get first class treatment, many for the first time



**TANKHA (CUTTING RIBBON)
AND CHIEF MINISTER
SHIVRAJ SINGH CHOUHAN
AT THE RAHAT CAMP**

| By Ambreesh Mishra |

Crowds of over 10,000 people are usually seen at political events, religious congregations or live entertainment shows. But for a week from March 6, an indoor stadium in the tribal-dominated Mandla district of Madhya Pradesh turned into a mammoth hospital as people from the region assembled for a rare medical camp, RAHAT, organised by the state Government in collaboration with other organisations. By the time a tired group of doctors, paramedics and volunteers wound up the camp on the evening of March 13, the final figures of 49,634 out patient department (OPD) patients at the stadium and 2,206 follow-ups at four hospitals were in the running for a Guinness record.

The camp gives a valuable insight into the health problems of tribals and the Government's fractured healthcare system. But for the people, the camp was a blessing as most would not have received any treatment in their lives, including those suffering from life-threatening diseases. Dr Taki Raza, head of the department of Orthopaedics, Jabalpur Medical College, recalls the case

of a 23-year-old tribal man who was cured of his deformity by 70 per cent after having been severely burnt in his teens. Many preventable problems, including club feet, in which the feet turn inward, cerebral palsy and those related to child-birth were noticed. According to the doctors, the prime reason for the high incidence of cerebral palsy were the unscientific, often dangerous, home deliveries carried out by ill-trained midwives, which also led to many other gynaecological problems.

"The response was overwhelming. Thankfully, we were prepared and managed things just fine in the end, but only barely so," says Vivek Tankha, the Additional Solicitor General of India, who organised the camp in collaboration with the state government and Rotary International. The camp showed that Government efforts to force doctors to serve in rural areas have not borne fruit. At present, nearly 2,700 posts of medical officers remain vacant. Even as the state Government sits down to study the findings, the common people too are getting a taste of modern medicine. ■